



Olympus Stylus 1030 SW

Olympus has some nice presentation while showing the slideshows and image previews. Even the Stylus 1030 SW comes with it. The user interface also is very similar to the MU 1010 model. The camera, like a mobile phone, can be left on and used as a clock. The panorama feature that allows you to shoot and stitch multiple images together also works rather well.

Although the whole camera is built like a brick, there are small design issues—the USB port door is a little dicey while opening, and clicks open suddenly. There is no better way to sum up this camera but to say that this would be the ideal camera if you are the type of person who drops expensive gadgets from time to time into water or have them run over.

Canon Digital IXUS 85 IS

The Canon Digital IXUS 85 IS is the cheapest of all the cameras in the above Rs 16,000 category. A part of the IXUS family of Canon cameras, the 85 IS is compact like its other sibling the IXUS 80 IS. A light, but well-built camera, it has a rather plain design. It is compact and something that will

easily fit into a shirt pocket. It is also the lightest of the cameras in its category. The door bay for the battery and memory card are a little flimsy and held together by a simple and somewhat weak mechanism.

Selecting modes is done by using a slider on the back. In terms of performance, it matches the Canon IXUS 960 IS, but manages to beat the Olympus Stylus 1030 SW and the Samsung NV24HD by a decent margin. Although there is grain in the photos, detail is maintained all throughout. The zoom quality also is good, but the camera doesn't quite judge the exposure accurately, which results in slightly underexposed photos. This is something seen in most other Canon's. The flash shot is quite impressive. It is powerful but not overpowering. This means the photos are well lit up, but without losing a lot of detail. Colour also isn't affected a lot.

For those who want as many megapixels as they can, you will be happy to know that the IXUS 85 IS is a 10 MP camera. The buttons on the rear are large and flat, so using

them is no problem despite the camera's small form. The user interface menus are also similar to most of the other Canon cameras.

A little more zoom would have been nicer but as it is, it is already a very good camera in all aspects. A user who wants manual focus in a camera will be disappointed, and should look for one of the cameras in the Rs 10,001 to Rs 16,000 category. With a price of just Rs 16,995 it still manages to impress in all departments.

Canon Digital IXUS 960 IS

If you thought the Rs 16,000 and above category was reserved for ultra-compact cameras, then you've guessed wrong. The Canon IXUS 960 IS is a slightly bulkier yet pocketable camera. The camera has been moulded better than the 85 IS with a smooth finished metal body. This camera unlike the 85 IS is a 12.1 MP one.

Like the IXUS 85 IS, the IXUS 960 too showed up darker mages while zooming into the scene. The larger megapixel shoot also meant more grain. Image clarity also suffered a bit in all other test shots as compared to the IXUS 85 IS.

The 960 IS has touch sensitive keys on the rear for easy control. The screen is a little tiny with a thick bezel around it. The battery door is sturdier than the IXUS 85 IS. The body, because of the material, also heats up a bit over time. Like the slider on the IXUS 85 IS, the modes on the IXUS 960 IS are changed using a small dial, and playback of the images can be done using a button instead of using the dial to switch to the playback mode.



Canon Digital IXUS 85 IS

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This 12.1 MP camera with its quality comes at a price. It is also the costliest camera of the test at Rs 24,995. Like the IXUS 85 IS, this too lacks a few manual controls. Even though the overall scores in performance are pretty much the same as the IXUS 85 IS, and the features scores no different, the IXUS 960 IS is dearer by Rs 8,000.

The Only Ultrazoom Olympus SP-570 UZ

While most buyers look for compact and fashionable cameras, there are the other few who want as much performance and features as they can get from a camera. These are the people who would look for a good D-SLR. The few irritating things that tag along with D-SLR's, and the higher costs stop people from opting for one.

This is where cameras like the 10 MP Olympus SP-570 UZ come in to bridge the gap between compact point and shoot cameras, and D-SLR's. We've seen many such cam-

eras in the past. The Olympus SP-570 UZ is one of the newer ones to hit the market. This is an ultra zoom camera that comes with an inbuilt 20X optical zoom. Olympus has tried to make this look and function as much as a D-SLR as possible. The body is the heaviest of all the cameras that we received, and is also one of the sturdiest. It is a little smaller than most D-SLR's though, and uses 4 AA batteries to operate. Its bulk also makes it a little uncomfortable to hold.

Zooming is done using a ring, but it only acts as a controller for the motor moving the lens. The zooming is not as smooth as a D-SLR, and it can get a little annoying because of the delay and inaccuracy. Zooming into photos has to be done with one of the clicking-rotating dials. The eyepiece is a poor quality LCD screen. Everything else seems



Canon Digital IXUS 960 IS

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